international institutions, deeper social interactions, and cultural affinities were certainly desirable but proved ultimately subordinate to more powerful interest-driven forces. Both the longer historical narrative and the outline of India's policy priorities appear to support this idea and run counter to the belief, popular in some academic circles, that India is driven primarily by post-colonial resentment or by prestige or status in international affairs.

Third, India's foreign policy has long been connected to domestic objectives. India has since Independence sought to use foreign relations to accelerate its domestic economic, social, and technological development while leveraging its domestic strengths internationally. But while the goal of a 'self-reliant India' is a worthy one, particularly in critical sectors where India can be exposed to vulnerabilities by adversaries, that goal will often require greater international cooperation rather than isolationism. In fact, as several examples from India's own experience in higher education, agriculture, public health, telecommunications, and infrastructure reveal, India has often prospered most when it has benefited instrumentally from foreign partnerships. Other countries, not least Japan and China, also offer useful lessons for India. Equating self-reliance with isolationism has often proved detrimental to Indian interests in the long run.

Fourth, readers of Part II: Strategy might notice the degree to which China's rise and behaviour today inform almost all aspects of India's external interactions. As the historical overview makes clear, China is not a new factor in India's foreign policy. But it is an increasingly dominant one. Whether India's trade, industrial, or technology policy; its engagement with the neighbourhood, Pakistan, Indian Ocean, and Indo–Pacific; its partnerships with the United States, Europe, Russia, and Japan; or its approach to global governance and multilateral institutions, China looms increasingly large in India's strategic consciousness. Indeed, China's rise is likely the primary factor influencing India's grand strategy today. Understanding that will be vital to students, observers, and practitioners of India's foreign policy.